



image of the PCI, which has often found itself embroiled in controversy over the years. Infighting, corruption — it's the usual menu.

That aside, the Paralympic vertical in India needs sustained attention, especially for a campaign the administration was so confident would succeed.

"Media rights are a crucial aspect of contributing to the Paralympics. No one wanted to purchase the bundle. We individually bought the rights to the feed and then approached Jio. The hesitation was there because no one believed we would win so many medals," Satyanarayana recollects.

The PCI also partnered with Zomato to amplify the stories of success from the Indian camp and assembled a sizable social media team to generate content from within the contingent.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's contribution too has been vital, not just as an elected official but as someone with the largest social media presence in the nation.

"He mentions us in his speeches,

shares our stories on his radio shows, and spends his birthday with disabled children in Navsari. That visibility, after being invisible for so long, goes a long way," Deepa adds.

#### Tip of the iceberg

But this is just the beginning. As para sports continue to evolve in India and around the world, Jhajharia and Co. need to find ways to keep the assembly line of talent running and ensure that facilities can keep up with the growing demand.

"Junior and sub-junior talent identification is the first order of business. We need to go into every district and scout for talent," Jhajharia explains. "If we start now, we can have them ready — if not for 2028, then at least for 2032."

He also highlights the potential within the Armed Forces.

"There are several soldiers with injuries or disabilities who we can induct into the Paralympic fold," he said.

Jhajharia hopes to adopt some of the best practices he observed during the Paris Games into India's

**A star is born:** Sheetal Devi being greeted with an enormous garland during a felicitation programme in Chennai. PTI

para sports programmes. He specifically mentions Tajikistan and its success in blind sports, which he hopes Indian officials can learn from during an exposure trip to the country and come back with ideas to enhance the Indian systems.

"Swimming is another area where we want to increase participation. If we improve participation, our chances of winning medals will also increase." For Kamath, improving India's performance in team sports is the ultimate marker of growth.

"If you notice, we weren't represented in any team sport this time. I think the maturity of an ecosystem is demonstrated when you don't just produce one or two players with potential, but when you can produce a full team of 15. If we can aim for that, I believe many other things will start falling into place."